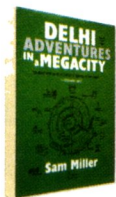


Mad Dogs and an ENGLISHMAN

A BBC journalist produces, quite literally, a walking encyclopaedia on Delhi



DELHI: ADVENTURES IN A MEGACITY
by SAM MILLER
Penguin/Viking
Price: Rs 499
Pages: 291

By Dilip Bobb

It's always unnerving for a reviewer when a book is released with fulsome praise from celebrity authors on the jacket. This one, by BBC's Sam Miller, has tributes from William Dalrymple, Khushwant Singh and Mark Tully. That's heavy artillery in anyone's book. It's common marketing strategy for publishers but it is diluted by the fact that the authors who oblige invariably have a connection to

the same publishing house.

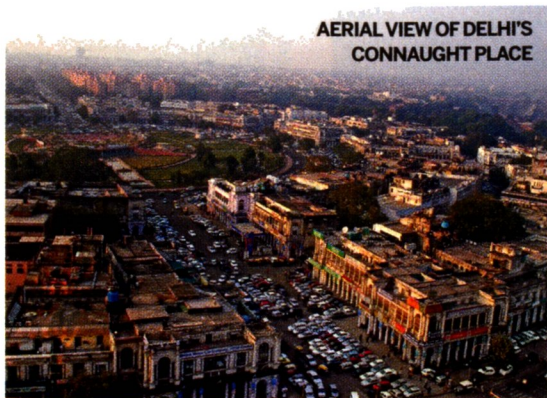
The other problem is that Delhi's history and contemporary status has made it the subject of innumerable books. So what does Miller, shorn of the publicity hosannas, bring to a crowded table? For one, this is not a coffee table book full of pretty pictures and historical nostalgia. He instead sets out to confirm the old saying that only mad dogs and Englishmen go out in the noonday sun. It's a sweaty, painful journey of discovery but Miller is clearly made of stern stuff. He married an Indian and has lived and worked in India for close to two decades before taking up permanent residence. Like many migrants to this anarchic, multi-layered city, his was a love-hate relationship, "a warts-and-all devotee" as he puts it.

Unlike, say Mumbai or Kolkata, Delhi often begs description. There is very little in common between east Delhi, west Delhi and the north while south Delhi exists in a cocoon by itself. Then there is the clash of civilisations represented by Old Delhi and New Delhi, separated by class, com-

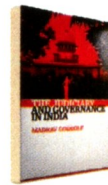
munity, geography, history and economics. Concrete jungles are given relief by the largest expanse of greenery in any Indian metro. A city of immigrants, not many of its residents have a sense of belonging or loyalty. Unlike other states or union territories, there is no local language or cuisine, no ethnic identity, it is all bastardised from surrounding states, mainly Punjab. Moreover, tens of thousands of inhabitants work here but live in the satellite towns of Gurgaon and Noida.

Miller literally follows an unorthodox route to research this book: he turns *flaneur*, a French word for someone who wanders aimlessly through cities. That is what differentiates this book from others: it's literally a walking encyclopaedia on contemporary Delhi, a unique if painfully acquired perspective on the city and its people. It's not random either. Starting from Connaught Place, the city's centre, he charts a spiral course, taking highways and alleys, dirt tracks and no tracks, rural and urban, meeting people from every class and community, mainly those from the city's underbelly, to portray a megacity groaning under the weight of its own contradictions.

Being white, his peregrinations result in strange encounters but allows him to form impressions and travel to areas where most long time residents have never been. Indeed, if Delhi has a common character, it is the revulsion against walking even a minuscule distance. Miller does the opposite and therein, as they say, hangs a tale. This is not a great book on Delhi—much of it covers familiar ground—but it is unique because of the approach: he takes the roads less travelled. Other visitors get Delhi belly. Miller gets Delhi's underbelly. ■



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